

1 / 5 | Ages 3-4 | 10 minutes

A picnic for three toys

What we are practising

Match one object to each guest and count a small set.

What you need

Three soft toys / Three unbreakable cups / Three cloth napkins

Use folded towels as pretend plates.

Before you begin

Seat the toys in a row on the floor.

Stay with your child and use large, intact, age-appropriate materials.

Try it together

1. Give one cup to the first toy and invite your child to finish.
2. Touch and count the cups together: one, two, three.
3. Add one napkin per toy and check whether anyone has none or two.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Does every guest have exactly one cup?

Space to explore

2 / 5 | Ages 3-4 | 10 minutes

Sock pair search

What we are practising

Match objects by observable features.

What you need

Three pairs of large clean socks

Match pairs of washcloths with different colours or textures.

Before you begin

Separate and mix the socks on a clear surface.

Stay with your child and use large, intact, age-appropriate materials.

Try it together

1. Pick one sock and describe its colour and pattern.
2. Invite your child to find its partner and place them together.
3. Repeat, then count the pairs rather than individual socks.

Talk, draw or show your idea

What makes these two a pair?

Space to explore

3 / 5 | Ages 3-4 | 5 minutes

Clap and count

What we are practising

Link number words to individual actions.

What you need

No materials

Tap a knee or blink instead of clapping.

Before you begin

Choose a comfortable seated or standing position.

Stay with your child and use large, intact, age-appropriate materials.

Try it together

1. Clap twice slowly while saying “one, two”.
2. Ask your child to copy, then try one or three claps.
3. Let your child lead a small group of claps for you to count.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Can we make exactly three taps and then stop?

Space to explore

4 / 5 | Ages 3-4 | 10 minutes

Long and short paths

What we are practising

Compare lengths using a shared starting point.

What you need

Two towels of different lengths

Use two strips of paper laid flat.

Before you begin

Roll the towels and place one end of each at the same line.

Stay with your child and use large, intact, age-appropriate materials.

Try it together

1. Trace each path with a finger, starting at the shared line.
2. Ask which reaches farther and name it longer.
3. Move one towel forward, then realign the starts before comparing again.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Why should the paths start in the same place?

Space to explore

5 / 5 | Ages 3-4 | 10 minutes

Shape parking spaces

What we are practising

Recognise circles, triangles and squares by their outlines.

What you need

Paper / Crayons / Three large shape cards prepared by an adult

Draw all shapes and point to matches instead of using cards.

Before you begin

Draw one circle, triangle and square on a sheet and on separate large cards.

Stay with your child and use large, intact, age-appropriate materials.

Try it together

1. Trace a circle and notice its curved edge.
2. Match each card to its parking space.
3. Turn the square card and ask whether it still belongs in the square space.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Which shape has three straight sides?

Space to explore

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

1. A picnic for three toys

A little hint

Point to each guest and its place in turn.

Answer / what to notice

Three guests need three cups and three napkins, one each.

Pairing guests and cups lets us check the count without guessing.

Make it easier

Begin with two toys.

Take it further

Add a fourth guest and work out what is missing.

Another day, away from the screen

Help count places at a real family meal.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

2. Sock pair search

A little hint

Compare length and pattern as well as colour.

Answer / what to notice

Three pairs contain six socks; each pair has two matching socks.

Matching may use more than one feature when colours are similar.

Make it easier

Use two very different pairs.

Take it further

Add a sock without a partner and identify it.

Another day, away from the screen

Let your child help match the next small laundry load.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

3. Clap and count

A little hint

Move one finger for each sound.

Answer / what to notice

Three taps means three separate sounds; the pause signals the end.

Slow, separate actions make one-to-one counting easier to follow.

Make it easier

Keep every group to one or two actions.

Take it further

Try groups up to five without speeding up.

Another day, away from the screen

Count gentle steps between two nearby places.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

4. Long and short paths

A little hint

Line up the near ends before looking at the far ends.

Answer / what to notice

The path extending farther from an aligned start is longer.

Moving an object changes its position, not its length.

Make it easier

Use paths with a large difference in length.

Take it further

Put three paths in order from shortest to longest.

Another day, away from the screen

Compare two books' heights by lining up their bottoms.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

5. Shape parking spaces

A little hint

Trace and count one side at a time.

Answer / what to notice

A triangle has three sides; turning a square does not change it into a different shape.

An outline's features matter more than its colour or direction.

Make it easier

Match just circles and squares.

Take it further

Draw a taller triangle and find its family.

Another day, away from the screen

Spot these shapes on familiar packaging together.